

Chapter 15: When Staying Becomes a Choice

Jenny didn't tell him to leave again.

That was the problem.

She should have.

She usually did.

But this time, she just stood there.

Quiet.

Watching him like he had somehow become part of the room without permission.

Austin didn't move either.

Not impatient.

Not pushy.

Just present.

Finally, Jenny broke the silence first.

"You can't just say things like that."

Austin tilted his head slightly.

"Which part?"

"All of it."

A pause.

Then softly—

"Then I'll stop."

Jenny frowned.

"...That's not what I meant."

"I know."

That made her stop.

Because he didn't sound confused.

He sounded certain.

Too certain.

Jenny crossed her arms tightly.

"This isn't normal."

Austin nodded once.

"I agree."

"That's not comforting."

"It wasn't meant to be."

A beat.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You're making this complicated."

Austin looked at her.

"I think it already was."

That landed too close to truth.

Jenny looked away.

Bad habit.

But today, it didn't help.

Because even when she wasn't looking at him...

She still felt him there.

"So what now?" she asked quietly.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"Now I stop pretending I don't come here for you."

Jenny's breath caught.

She turned back sharply.

"That's not— you can't just decide that."

"I already did."

"You don't get to just decide things like that about people."

"I'm not deciding for you," he said calmly. "I'm being honest about me."

That silence after was heavier than anything before it.

Jenny felt her chest tighten.

Anger.

Confusion.

Something else she refused to name.

"You don't know what you're doing to me," she said.

Austin's gaze softened slightly.

"Then tell me."

Jenny shook her head immediately.

"No."

A pause.

Then quieter—

"Because I don't know either."

That honesty hit harder than anything else.

Jenny looked at him like she was trying to find the arrogance again.

The snob.

The man who demanded people be fired over a strand of hair.

But he wasn't that right now.

Not fully.

And that scared her more than anything.

Behind them, the restaurant started waking up.

Chairs scraping.

Kitchen noise rising.

Life continuing.

But between them...

It felt suspended.

Austin stepped slightly closer.

Not enough to pressure her.

Just enough that she couldn't ignore him.

"I don't want to make your life harder," he said.

Jenny let out a short, humorless laugh.

"Too late."

That made something flicker in his expression.

Guilt.

Maybe.

Jenny noticed.

And immediately regretted it.

"I'm fine," she added quickly.

"You're not."

"I am."

"You're surviving," he corrected gently.

That word.

Surviving.

It hit differently.

Jenny's voice dropped.

"That's normal for me."

Austin shook his head slightly.

"It shouldn't be."

Silence again.

Jenny felt her control slipping.

Not dramatically.

Not all at once.

Just slowly.

Like something loosening she didn't notice she was holding.

She stepped back.

"I need to work."

Austin didn't stop her.

But he said quietly,

"I'll be here when you're done."

Jenny froze.

Then turned slightly.

"You always say that."

"And I always mean it."

Something in her chest twisted.

She hated that part the most.

Because it was true.

And consistency...

Was something she wasn't used to.

She walked away before she could think too much about it.

The day passed differently after that.

Jenny worked.

But she was aware of him.

Always.

At table seven.

Still there.

Not demanding attention.

But taking it anyway.

Every time she passed, she felt it.

That quiet pull.

Not forceful.

Worse.

Gentle.

By late afternoon, the restaurant slowed.

Jenny finally approached his table.

"You're still here," she said.

"Yes."

"You're not working?"

"I am."

She frowned.

"That doesn't look like work."

Austin glanced at his documents.

"It is."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You're avoiding your real work."

He looked up.

"You think this isn't real work?"

"You know what I mean."

A pause.

Then—

"I do both."

That made her hesitate.

"You can't just... split your life like that."

"I've always done that."

Jenny studied him.

"Between what?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then quietly—

"Who I am when I'm there," he nodded toward the city outside, "and who I am when I'm here."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"And who are you here?"

Silence.

Not avoidance.

Thought.

Then—

"I'm not sure yet."

That answer unsettled her more than anything else.

Because it sounded like the truth.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

"Finish your food," she said quietly.

Austin nodded once.

But before she left, he added softly,

"Jenny."

She stopped.

Didn't turn fully.

"Yes?"

A pause.

Then—

"I'm not leaving this time."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because for the first time...

She didn't know if that was a promise.

Or a warning.